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THEATRE ARTS

SPEECH ARTS

Speech Arts: Breath, Voice and Articulation

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The working voice: how breath supports sound, how resonance carries it, and the articulation drills that make a line audible from the back of a hall.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- breath
- resonance
- articulation
- projection
- warm-up

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Breath is the engine

Sound is made by air passing the vocal folds, and the folds are damaged by pushing. Breathe low, into the back and sides of the ribs, and let the abdominal wall move out as you inhale. On the voice, keep the ribs open and let the air come out in a controlled stream; do not squeeze the throat.

A useful drill: inhale for four counts, hiss for eight, then twelve, then sixteen, keeping the ribs wide and the shoulders still. Two minutes a day for a month changes a voice more than any amount of shouting in rehearsal.

Resonance, not volume

A voice that carries is a voice with ring, not a voice with force. Find the forward resonance by humming on a comfortable note with the lips closed and the teeth apart, then opening into "ma, me, mi, mo, mu" without losing the buzz. The mask of the face should feel alive.

Projection is direction, not loudness. Speak to the back wall, not at the floor; lift the soft palate; keep the jaw free. An actor who fills a hall with a resonant voice can then whisper and still be heard in the tenth row.

Articulation

English has twenty-four consonants and around twenty vowels, and most stage speech problems are consonant problems: final -s, -t, -d and -k dropped, and "th" replaced by "d" or "t". Drill the tongue, the lips and the soft palate separately, then together.

Standard drills: tongue twisters slowly, then at performance speed; the vowel ladder on one breath; the "red leather, yellow leather" sequence; and the reading of a paragraph with every consonant exaggerated, then at normal strength. Exaggeration is the training; the performance is the middle.

The warm-up and the care of the voice

Warm up for ten minutes before a show: neck and shoulder release, yawn-sigh, lip trills, humming, tongue stretches, then a text. Warm down after: a gentle hum, water, silence. Do not whisper, because whispering strains more than speaking.

Avoid alcohol and smoke before a performance, and drink water through the day rather than in the five minutes before the entrance. If the voice is hoarse for more than two weeks, that is a medical matter, not a technique problem.

From drill to text

Drills are not performance. The point of a warm-up is to arrive at the text with options: a voice that can be loud or quiet, fast or slow, high or low, without strain. After the drills, speak a speech you know and change one parameter at a time, listening for what the change does to the meaning.

Work with a metronome for pace and with a partner at the back of the room for projection. A partner who raises a hand when a word is lost is a better teacher than a mirror.

Finally, record yourself once a week for a term. The recording is the only evidence of progress, and it is the thing a student most needs when the voice feels stuck. Keep the files; in twelve weeks the change will be audible.

Voice in a hall with no air conditioning

Heat, dust and a generator change the voice. Drink water through the day, avoid iced drinks before a show, and warm up longer in the cold of an air-conditioned hall and less in the heat where the voice is already loose.

When the hall has no sound system, projection is a technique of direction and support, not of shouting: speak past the audience to the back wall, use the consonants to carry, and let the body do the work the throat should not.

Exercises

1. Do the four-eight-twelve-sixteen hiss count and note the count you can reach without tension.
2. Hum for one minute, then speak a speech; describe the difference in the resonance.
3. Record a two-minute speech, listen back, and mark every dropped final consonant.
4. Build a ten-minute warm-up for a company and lead it before a rehearsal.

Where to read more

Cicely Berry, Voice and the Actor (1973)

Kristin Linklater, Freeing the Natural Voice (1976)

Patsy Rodenburg, The Right to Speak (1992)

Irvah Lester Winter, Public Speaking: Principles and Practice (1912)

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